

Faculty Connection, Belonging, and Structured Support as Predictors of Student Retention, Persistence, and Graduation

An Evidence Review for Evaluating Faculty-Led Skills Coaching in Online Counseling Education

Working Draft — Prepared for Internal Review

Abstract

This white paper evaluates whether a faculty-led skills coaching intervention for counseling students can reasonably be justified as a retention, persistence, progression, and graduation support in an online university context. The strongest defensible conclusion is bounded but clear: faculty relationships, individualized support, perceived institutional care, self-efficacy, and belonging or mattering are consistently associated with student persistence and completion, although the strength and mechanism of these relationships vary by population and outcome. For adult, online, graduate, and nontraditional learners, these factors interact with environmental and academic demands that often carry as much or more explanatory weight than broad social integration (Bean & Metzner, 1985; Cabrera et al., 1992). Direct causal evidence for faculty-led counseling microskills coaching is limited, but adjacent literatures in advising, coaching, mentoring, online retention, counselor development, and deliberate practice support the plausibility of such a program as student-success infrastructure rather than a remedial add-on (Donaldson et al., 2025; Irvine et al., 2024). The document recommends maintaining the Skills Enhancement Lab while evaluating it with outcome measures proportionate to the claims the evidence can support.

Keywords: counselor education, student retention, skills coaching, online learning, self-efficacy, belonging, persistence, CACREP

Review Purpose and Scope

This review addresses a practical institutional question: whether a structured, faculty-led skills coaching program for counseling students can be defended as a retention, persistence, and completion intervention in a fully online counseling program. The question matters because high-touch supports are often scrutinized as labor-intensive costs unless they can be tied to outcomes that matter to deans, provosts, accreditation reviewers, and institutional research leaders.

The review proceeds in five steps. First, it defines the relevant outcomes precisely. Second, it identifies the strongest general predictors of retention and graduation in U.S. higher education. Third, it evaluates the specific evidence on faculty relationships, coaching, advising, mentoring, belonging, and perceived institutional support. Fourth, it examines population-specific evidence for online, graduate, adult, nontraditional, and counseling learners. Fifth, it translates the literature into a local evaluation and return-on-investment framework appropriate for the Skills Enhancement Lab.

Evidence Standards

Included sources emphasize Tier 1 evidence: peer-reviewed journal articles, meta-analyses, systematic reviews, seminal scholarly books, and major evidence reviews. Tier 2 sources, such as the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center, the National Center for Education Statistics, and the What Works Clearinghouse, are used for contextual statistics or practice guidance rather than for inflating causal claims.

Excluded or minimized sources include vendor white papers, blogs, marketing materials, and unsupported commentary. International studies are included only when the construct is transferable and U.S.-specific evidence is sparse. Throughout, correlational evidence is treated as evidence of association rather than proof of causation; quasi-experimental evidence is treated as stronger but still vulnerable to selection effects; randomized evidence is treated as the strongest basis for causal inference while still subject to generalizability limits.

Key Definitions

- **Retention:** continued enrollment at the same institution from one period to the next.
- **Persistence:** continued progress toward a credential, whether or not the student remains at the same institution.
- **Stop-out:** a temporary interruption in enrollment rather than permanent departure.
- **Graduation/Completion:** earning the intended credential.
- **Time-to-degree:** elapsed time from initial enrollment to degree conferral.

These distinctions matter because an intervention may improve short-term persistence without changing graduation rates, or reduce delay without changing first-year retention. Institutional decisions should therefore avoid treating all student-success outcomes as interchangeable.

Executive Summary

The best available evidence supports a clear but proportionate conclusion: student retention, persistence, and graduation are shaped not only by academic performance and financial conditions but also by the quality of students' relationships with faculty and staff, the degree to which they perceive institutional support, and whether they receive sustained, personalized academic guidance (Tinto, 2012; Robbins et al., 2004). Five decades of retention scholarship converge on the importance of meaningful faculty contact, clear expectations, academic and social support, feedback, and active involvement (Astin, 1984; Pascarella & Terenzini, 2005).

At the same time, work on nontraditional student attrition shows that adult and online learners often persist or depart based less on broad campus social integration and more on academic utility, environmental constraints, support, and psychological variables such as satisfaction, efficacy, and goal commitment (Bean & Metzner, 1985). This distinction is important for evaluating a faculty-led coaching program in an online counseling program.

The most defensible institutional claim is not that faculty-led counseling microskills coaching has already been proven to cause higher graduation rates for counseling students specifically. Rather, the program targets mechanisms that the broader higher education literature consistently identifies as relevant to persistence and completion, and those mechanisms are especially plausible in online, adult, and professionally vulnerable learner populations (Donaldson et al., 2025; Strayhorn, 2018). The institutional implication is restrained but meaningful: a faculty-led Skills Enhancement Lab should be treated as plausible student-success infrastructure that warrants continuation and rigorous local evaluation.

Problem Statement

Student attrition, stop-out, delayed progression, and extended time-to-degree remain persistent challenges in U.S. higher education. The National Student Clearinghouse Research Center (2025) reported that the national six-year completion rate for fall 2019 starters was 61.1%, and its persistence reports continue to show substantial loss between entry and later terms.

Online programs face additional risk. Dropout estimates are often reported in the 25 to 40% range, compared with roughly 10 to 20% for on-campus programs (Levy, 2007; Muljana & Luo, 2019). Graduate student attrition has likewise been described as a hidden crisis, with doctoral noncompletion frequently cited in the 30 to 50% range (Lovitts & Nelson, 2000).

For counseling education, the issue is not only enrollment management. Students are developing professional identity, counseling competence, and readiness for practicum and internship under CACREP (2024) standards. Struggles with microskills can trigger anxiety, diminished self-efficacy, delayed progression, and withdrawal (Friedlander et al., 1986; Daniels & Larson, 2001). In an online program, these vulnerabilities may be amplified because students have fewer informal opportunities for live coaching and low-stakes performance feedback.

Research Questions

1. What are the strongest predictors of student retention, persistence, graduation, and shorter time-to-degree in U.S. higher education?
2. To what extent do faculty relationships, mentoring, coaching, advising, instructor presence, and perceived institutional support predict these outcomes?
3. How important are belonging, mattering, academic integration, social integration, and engagement?
4. What does the literature specifically show for online, graduate, adult, nontraditional, and counseling students?

5. Is there evidence that a structured support program such as faculty-led skills coaching could reasonably improve retention-related outcomes?
6. Through what mechanisms might such a program work, including self-efficacy, anxiety reduction, identity development, perceived support, and clarity of next steps?
7. What are the strongest counterarguments and limitations in the evidence base?
8. What should be measured locally to determine whether the Skills Enhancement Lab is worth keeping?

Theoretical Foundations

Tinto's Model and Institutional Action

Tinto's early model of student departure emphasized academic and social integration, but his later work shifted from explaining why students leave to specifying what institutions must do (Tinto, 2012). In *Completing College*, Tinto identifies four institutional conditions: expectations, support, assessment and feedback, and involvement. A faculty-led coaching model maps directly onto these conditions by clarifying expectations, providing individualized support, generating frequent performance feedback, and requiring active student participation.

That said, the framework has documented limits when applied to commuter, online, and adult populations (Davidson & Wilson, 2013; Tierney, 1992). These limits matter for institutional arguments that treat social integration as the dominant driver of persistence among working-adult online counseling students.

Bean and Metzner on Nontraditional Attrition

Bean and Metzner's (1985) model was developed specifically because traditional residential retention frameworks under-explained nontraditional students' experiences. Their framework emphasizes environmental variables such as employment, finances, and family responsibilities, along with academic variables and psychological outcomes such as satisfaction, stress, and goal commitment. For adult and online students, broad social integration often matters less than academic usefulness, perceived support, and the ability to navigate external constraints (Cabrera et al., 1992).

For the Skills Enhancement Lab, the stronger argument is therefore not that coaching recreates campus belonging but that it reduces academic ambiguity, increases perceived competence, and helps students remain enrolled despite environmental pressure.

Astin, Pascarella, Terenzini, and Kuh

Astin's (1984) involvement theory and Pascarella and Terenzini's (2005) synthesis both support the idea that informal and substantive interactions with faculty are among the experiences most consistently associated with persistence, aspirations, and intellectual development. Kuh's (2008) work on high-impact practices adds that environments marked by feedback, meaningful interaction, reflection, and application are especially beneficial for students with weaker initial preparation.

Belonging and Mattering

Strayhorn's (2018) work establishes belonging as a meaningful predictor of student engagement, well-being, and persistence. For online counseling students, mattering may be the more actionable construct (Schlossberg, 1989). A student may not feel deeply integrated into a broad virtual campus yet may remain enrolled because a faculty coach provides credible evidence that the institution sees their struggle and expects their success.

Community of Inquiry and Online Persistence

The Community of Inquiry framework (Garrison et al., 2000) identifies teaching presence, social presence, and cognitive presence as interdependent dimensions of online learning quality. Boston et al. (2009), analyzing over 28,000 student records, found that social presence indicators accounted for meaningful variance in re-enrollment. Moore's (1997) transactional distance theory similarly predicts that perceived psychological distance from the instructor increases dropout risk. A coaching program reduces perceived distance and increases instructional presence for vulnerable students.

Faculty Contact, Advising, Coaching, and Mentoring

General Higher Education Evidence

The strongest direct intervention evidence in the broader student-success literature comes from large advising and coaching studies. Bettinger and Baker's (2014) randomized evaluation of InsideTrack found that coached students were approximately 5 percentage points more likely to persist than comparison students, demonstrating that individualized coaching can affect persistence behavior, not merely satisfaction.

Comprehensive advising models can produce larger effects, but they are bundled interventions. The CUNY ASAP randomized trial showed an 18 percentage point increase in three-year graduation rates, but ASAP includes intensive advising, financial gap scholarships, transportation assistance, and structured scheduling (Scrivener et al., 2015; Weiss et al., 2019). That effect size reflects the full package, not coaching alone. The more defensible interpretation is that advising and coaching are important components of high-performing multi-component student-success systems. The What Works Clearinghouse (2024) guidance similarly endorses comprehensive, integrated advising rather than isolated or episodic contacts.

Graduate and Professional Education Evidence

Studies and reviews in doctoral and professional education repeatedly show that the quality of advising, mentoring, and supervision is associated with persistence, completion, and professional development (Eby et al., 2008; Evans et al., 2018). A recent systematic scoping review by Donaldson et al. (2025) specifically examined academic coaching in graduate healthcare and medical education and found meaningful associations between structured coaching and academic and professional outcomes. This literature should be interpreted carefully because much of it is observational and studies often examine bundled rather than isolated supports.

Online, Adult, and Nontraditional Learners

Online adult learners commonly balance employment, caregiving, and academic work, and their persistence decisions are shaped by flexibility, instructional clarity, support responsiveness, and the perceived feasibility of continuing under strain (Hart, 2012; Muljana & Luo, 2019). NCES data show students aged 25 and older are six times more likely to have dependents than traditional-age undergraduates (Rose et al., 2024). Reviews of online retention repeatedly identify institutional support, instructor communication, belonging or connectedness, and course design quality as important contributors to persistence (Walsh et al., 2024). Support structures are not peripheral extras in online learning; they are part of the basic architecture of persistence.

Counseling-Specific and Adjacent Evidence

Counseling Trainee Anxiety and Self-Efficacy

The Skills Enhancement Lab Cycle 1 analysis appropriately interprets student-reported themes of anxiety reduction, hands-on practice, and increased confidence as aligning with established constructs while explicitly acknowledging the design cannot support causal claims. That restraint is methodologically sound. The counselor training literature does provide adjacent support: Friedlander et al. (1986) documented role conflict and anxiety in counselor trainees, and Daniels and Larson (2001) found that performance feedback can affect counseling self-efficacy and anxiety.

Deliberate Practice and Coaching

Deliberate practice frameworks are increasingly visible in counselor education, including Irvine et al.'s (2024) deliberate practice coaching framework for enhancing clinical competencies. Students improve complex interpersonal skills through structured rehearsal, immediate feedback, correction, and repeated attempts (Ericsson, 2008). This is closely aligned with the described function of the Skills Enhancement Lab. Deliberate practice strengthens mechanism plausibility but does not by itself establish distal outcomes such as retention or graduation.

What the Evidence Supports and Does Not Support

The literature strongly supports that personalized, sustained faculty or staff support is associated with better persistence outcomes (Bettinger & Baker, 2014; Kuh, 2008), that online and adult learners are especially sensitive to support structures that reduce ambiguity and communicate institutional care (Walsh et al., 2024), and that self-efficacy, anxiety reduction, and perceived support are plausible mechanisms linking coaching to improved continuation (Bandura, 1997; Robbins et al., 2004).

The evidence does not support a claim that faculty-led counseling microskills coaching has been proven to cause higher graduation rates in master's counseling students specifically. It does not justify importing effect sizes from bundled programs such as ASAP and attributing them to coaching alone, and it does not support using unattributed cost ratios in front of institutional leaders.

Counterarguments and Limitations

Several counterarguments deserve acknowledgement. Many belonging, mentoring, and advising studies are observational rather than randomized, limiting causal inference. Students who opt into voluntary support may differ systematically from non-participants, producing selection bias. Counseling-specific direct evidence remains sparse, requiring adjacent inference throughout this review. These limitations are real but not fatal. Institutional decisions routinely proceed under conditions of incomplete but convergent evidence. The responsible standard is proportionate claims, rigorous local testing, and transparent acknowledgment of what is not yet known.

Local Evaluation Recommendations

Proximal Outcomes

Immediate post-session measures should assess counseling self-efficacy, anxiety, mattering, clarity of next steps, and perceived usefulness. The Counseling Activity Self-Efficacy Scales (CASES; Lent et al., 2003) administered pre- and post-term would provide robust validated data. Brief Likert items at session end can efficiently capture mechanism indicators.

Medium-Term Outcomes

Within-term measures should include course completion, course performance, successful progression toward practicum prerequisites, and repeat engagement with the lab. These indicators help test whether immediate psychological gains translate into academic behavior.

Distal Outcomes

Institutional measures should include term-to-term persistence, stop-out patterns, time-to-degree, and practicum readiness where linkable. Matched comparison or quasi-experimental analyses, such as propensity-score matching, would strengthen inference considerably more than satisfaction data alone.

Dosage and ROI

The institution should track session attendance as a predictor variable in outcome analyses to estimate whether multiple contacts are associated with stronger outcomes. ROI calculations should rely on actual tuition margin and compensation data. The most credible institutional claim is that retaining even a small fraction of at-risk students can offset coaching labor costs, but this requires local financial data to make the claim precisely.

Conclusion

The strongest conclusion supported by the literature is neither maximalist nor dismissive. Faculty-led skills coaching for online counseling students has not been proven by counseling-specific randomized trials to raise graduation rates. However, the intervention targets multiple mechanisms that the broader higher education literature consistently associates with persistence and completion, especially for online, adult, graduate, and nontraditional learners (Bean & Metzner, 1985; Bettinger & Baker, 2014; Strayhorn, 2018). The Skills Enhancement Lab should be retained and evaluated as legitimate student-success infrastructure. Its institutional

case is strongest when claims remain proportionate to the evidence, adjacent inference is clearly labeled, and local data are used to determine whether the program improves outcomes enough to justify ongoing investment.

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